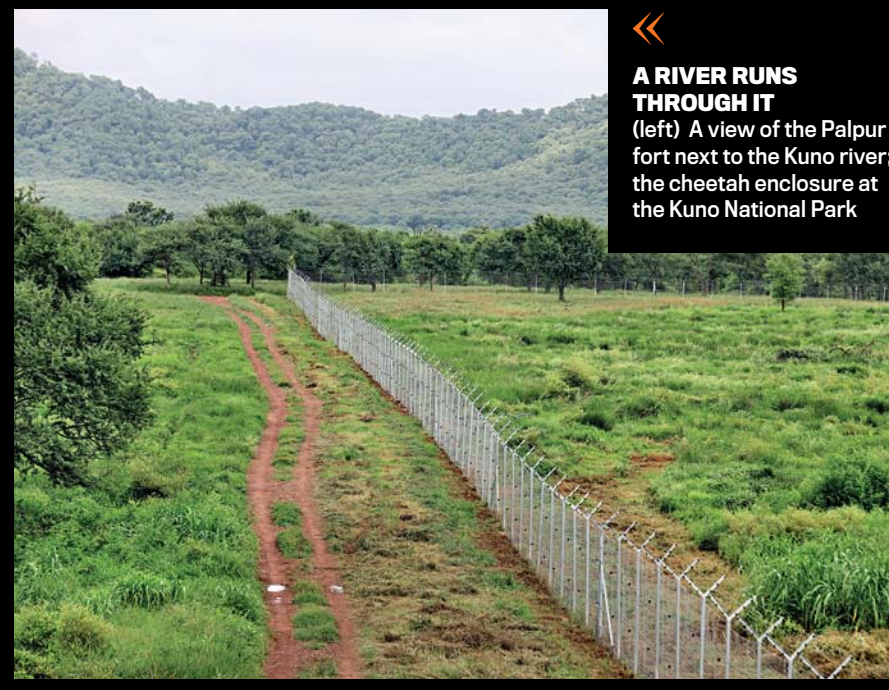




A RIVER RUNS THROUGH IT
(left) A view of the Palpur fort next to the Kuno river; the cheetah enclosure at the Kuno National Park

MUJEEB FARUQUI

KUNO WAS CHOSEN FOR ITS FOREST-GRASSLAND MOSAIC AND ARID/SEMI-ARID CLIMATE. ITS PREY BASE IS ADEQUATE, THOUGH THERE'S COMPETITION FROM LEOPARDS. IT HAD BEEN PRIMED FOR GIR'S LIONS, BY RELOCATING VILLAGES

less kingly types from Europe to India. Akbar had something like a cheetah fetish, and kept some 9,000 of them over his lifetime—1,000 being his peak stable strength. Samand Malik, his favourite cheetah, was decked out in a bejewelled coat, carried by liveried soldiers and featured on miniatures. But only one bred in captivity out of those thousands, Akbar's son Jahangir notes. All this caused a huge strain on the population in the wild.

THE DISAPPEARING...

At a much humbler ledge on the social pecking order, Dinesh Adivasi, a Sahariya tribal who lives in a 15 x 15 feet sandstone walled hut in Resham Colony, on the banks of the Kuno river in Sheopur district and works as a casual labourer, awaits the region's date with history in September 2022. His perspective offers a unique intersection between the tales of kings and ordinary folk: his forefathers probably participated as attendants in the hunting escapades of the Gwalior maharajas. Perhaps the last of two millennia of vicarious hunting.

The animal's numbers had declined enough by the dawn of the colonial era for cheetah coursing to have ebbed as a sport—even if surviving into the early 20th century, as a 1939 video and signs of the first translocations from Africa to feed India's scant base attest to. Those events were from another era—in the service of the hunting ethos, not guided by the ecological sciences. Witness the Gwalior maharaja's tryst with African lions. The ruler of Junagadh apparently did not allow him to hunt in his territories, according to conservationist Divyabhanusinh's 2005 book, *The Story of Asia's Lions*. A 1959 book by Col. Kesri Singh, the 'shikar officer' of Gwalior State and later of Jaipur—*The Tiger of Rajasthan*—also records how Maharaja Madho Rao Scindia sourced 12 lion cubs from Africa in 1920, bred and released them around Kuno. The animals later turned cattle-lifters and man-eaters and were ordered to be killed. One of them was shot in Panna and another in Jhansi.

The British, whose own taste for mass-scale hunting tilted towards big game, treated cheetahs like vermin, to be exterminated so as to create a larger niche for their prize trophies: tigers and lions. Cheetahs were bounty-hunted, with rewards ranging from Rs 6 to Rs 18 for adults. Says Mahesh Rangarajan, professor of history and environmental studies at Ashoka University: "Records from the British period suggest cheetahs were hunted for bounty as they were seen picking on sheep and goat. They were hunted for sport and were trapped too. Besides, the cheetah habitat was under pressure and shrinking from deforestation, clearing for agriculture. Most importantly, there was a sharp drop in its prey base, which led to a population collapse. This is true but for all of Asia where the cheetah was earlier found." Hunting records, says Rangarajan, show cheetah populations were reported from as far down south as Tirunelveli to Palamu in Jharkhand before going extinct.

Seventy-five years after the final bul-